

GROUNDED: In 10 years, two out of the three vulture species will be extinct

FLYING INTO UNCERTAINTY

An ambitious breeding-in-captivity project aims to save the endangered vulture by preventing it from feeding on carcasses rich in the killer diclofenac drug. It may be a classical case of too little too late.

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

Deep inside Bir Shikargah, in a wildlife sanctuary spread over two sq km near Pinjore off the Chandigarh-Shimla highway that was once the hunting ground for the Patiala royalty, a flock of vultures gorge on a freshly skinned goat carcass. Except for a few haggling crows, the 114-odd vultures have no dogs to compete with inside three wildlife aviaries, each roughly the size of a tennis court. For the vultures, it's a royal feast—they can relish it without the risk of diclofenac, a killer veterinary drug that has reportedly caused an alarming crash in vulture population across India since the mid-1990s.

Belonging to three critically endangered species—white-rumped, slender-billed and long-billed brought from Assam, Rajasthan, Maharashtra,

Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh—these vultures have been nesting at their new-found home, the Vulture Conservation Breeding Centre (VCBC), as part of an ambitious project to revive the near-extinct species of scavengers. Vultures are the most important avian scavengers in the world, feeding on dead and rotting carcasses of animals. These birds serve as nature's janitors, ridding our ecosystem of maggots and disease-carrying viruses.

Funded by the Britain-based Darwin Initiative for the Survival of Species and run by the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS), the Vulture Conservation Breeding Programme was one of two major recommendations of the vulture recovery plan formulated in 2004. The other was the complete ban on veterinary use of diclofenac. While the first VCBC

was set up at Pinjore as an expansion of an existing vulture care centre in 2005, last year the Union Government withdrew the licences to manufacture veterinary diclofenac formulations and ordered their phase-out within three months. But all this in vain.

The world's first major initiative at breeding vultures in captivity has been hit because state authorities take about four months in permitting BNHS experts to capture the birds. "The slow pace is a cause of worry. We desperately need more birds for a faster breeding programme," says BNHS Director A.R. Rahmani. "The odds against saving the vulture from going extinct are mounting by the day," says Vibhu Prakash, BNHS principal scientist in-charge of the project.

A recent BNHS monitoring study has revealed that 10 per cent of carcasses sampled across the country were